

The orchard cooperative

Every autumn the members of the orchard cooperative gather in the long barn to sort the harvest. The work begins before sunrise, when the first carts arrive from the upper slopes with crates of early pears still wet with dew.

Sorting is done by hand. Each fruit is turned once, checked for bruises and laid in one of three baskets: market, cider or compost. Children are allowed to help with the compost basket, which they consider the most important of the three.

In the afternoon the cider press runs without a pause. Its wooden screw creaks loudly enough to be heard from the road, and travellers often stop to ask whether they may taste the first jug of the season.

When the light fades the tables are cleared, lamps are lit and the accounts for the day are read aloud, so that everyone knows how many crates went to the market and how many barrels are waiting in the cellar.